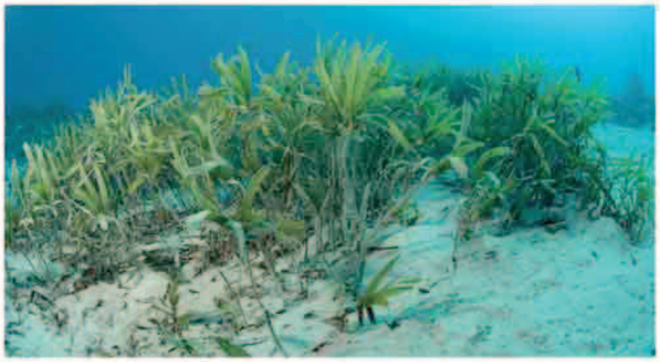
SHALLOW SEABED

The seabed of the continental shelf has an average depth of 490 ft (150 m). The deepest point offshore, at the shelf break, usually lies about 660 ft (200 m) below the waves. The shelf has a very shallow gradient, and is mostly covered with soft sand and mud. A lot of this is the result of coastal erosion, but some of the sand and mud is swept into the sea by rivers. It is mixed with the remains of microscopic marine plankton.

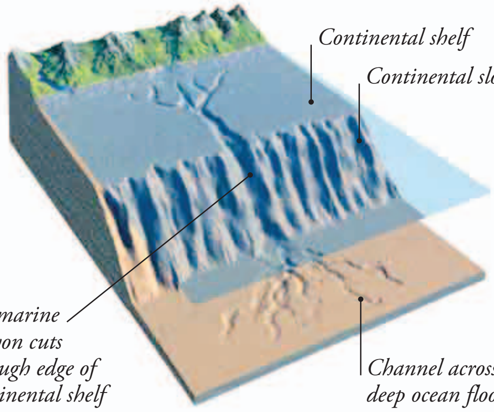


REEFS AND SANDBANKS

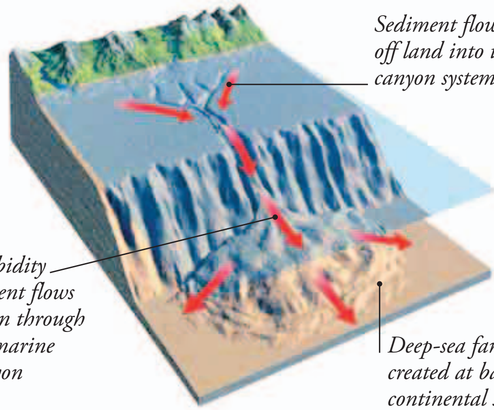
The soft seabed is dotted with rocky reefs, and in places the currents create shallow banks of sand and gravel. These hidden shallows have always been hazards for ships, especially in the days before there were accurate charts or ways of measuring ocean depth. As a result, the seabed of the continental shelf is littered with shipwrecks.

MUDFLOWS AND CANYONS

Vast amounts of sand, silt, and mud are carried off the land by big rivers and swept onto the seabed. These sediments pour off the continental shelf in powerful flows called turbidity currents, carving canyons in the continental slope. Some of these canyons are up to 2,600 ft (800 m) deep.



Submarine canyon



Turbidity current